Elements and Principles of Design: A Classmate's Reviewer

Think of it this way: the elements are the ingredients, and the principles are the recipe. You need both to make a good poster or tarpaulin.

The Elements of Design

There are seven elements, the basic parts of every artwork or layout.

- Line: a mark that connects two points. Lines can be straight, curved, thick, thin, or zigzag, or implied, like the direction a person in a photo is looking.
- Shape: a closed, flat area with two dimensions, height and width. Geometric shapes are mathematical, like circles and triangles. Organic shapes are free-flowing, like a leaf or a puddle.
- Form: a shape with three dimensions, so it adds depth. A circle is a shape, but a sphere is a form. On flat paper, artists suggest form with shading.
- Space: the area around, between, and inside objects. It can make a design feel crowded or calm.
- Color: what we see when light bounces off a surface and reaches our eyes. It has three properties: hue, value, and intensity.
- Value: how light or dark something is. A strip going from white through grays to black is called a value scale.
- Texture: how a surface feels or looks like it would feel. Actual texture can be touched, like the weave of a banig mat. Visual texture is only drawn or printed, like a photo of tree bark.

Positive and Negative Space

Positive space is the area taken up by the main subject. Negative space is the empty area around and between subjects. Beginners often ignore negative space, but giving your subject breathing room makes it easier to read.

Negative space can even form its own image. A famous example looks like a vase, but the empty sides form two faces looking at each other.

The Principles of Design

The principles describe how we arrange the elements so the work feels organized.

Balance

Balance is how visual weight is spread across a design.

- Symmetrical balance: both halves are mirror images, or nearly. It feels formal and stable, like the front of a church.
- Asymmetrical balance: the sides are different but still feel equal. One big photo on the left can be balanced by three small text blocks on the right. It feels relaxed and modern.
- Radial balance: parts spread out from a center point, like bicycle spokes, a sunflower, or the sun on our flag.

Contrast

Contrast is the difference between elements placed side by side: light and dark, big and small, rough and smooth, warm and cool. Black text on yellow is high contrast; light gray text on white is low contrast.

Emphasis

Emphasis creates a focal point, the part your eye lands on first. You get it through contrast, size, color, or placement. A poster should have one clear focal point, not five things shouting at once.

Movement

Movement is the path the viewer's eye travels through the work. Designers guide it with lines, arrows, the direction figures face, and sizes going from large to small.

Rhythm and Pattern

Pattern is the repeating of an element, like a motif in T'nalak cloth or floor tiles. Rhythm is the sense of movement from repetition with timing, like beats in music. Regular rhythm repeats the same thing evenly. Alternating rhythm switches between two things. Progressive rhythm changes step by step, like circles that slowly grow.

Proportion and Scale

Proportion is how the sizes of parts relate to each other within one design. Scale is the size of an object compared to something else, often the viewer or the real world. A giant painted mango on a fruit stand sign uses exaggerated scale to grab attention.

Unity and Variety

Unity is the feeling that every part belongs together, built by repeating fonts, colors, and alignment. Variety adds differences so the design is not boring. Too much unity is dull; too much variety is chaos. Aim for a healthy mix.

Applying It to a Poster

Say you are making a Buwan ng Wika poster.

- Pick one focal point, like a big title or central illustration, and emphasize it with size and contrast.
- Choose two or three colors and stick to them for unity.
- Use at most two fonts, one for the title and one for details.
- Decide on balance: symmetrical feels formal, asymmetrical feels lively.
- Leave negative space around the title.
- Arrange information so the eye moves from title, to picture, to date and venue.
- View it in grayscale to check value contrast. If text disappears, adjust it.
- Step back a few meters, since people read posters while walking.

Quick check

- Q: What is the difference between shape and form? A: Shape is flat with two dimensions, while form has three dimensions and shows depth.
- Q: What kind of balance has parts spreading out from a center? A: Radial balance.
- Q: What do we call the empty area around the main subject? A: Negative space.

- Q: Which principle creates a focal point? A: Emphasis.
- Q: What is the difference between proportion and scale? A: Proportion compares parts within a design, while scale compares an object's size to something outside it, like the viewer.